way to make publishing cheap and, within the limits of local censorship, international. But it does not give you any extra freedom. If you want freedom in the age of the Internet, you still have to fight for it yourself. Some people have referred to the transformation of Egypt in 2011 as the ‘Twitter Revolution’, as if Mubarak was toppled by a flash mob in Silicon Valley. There’s a reason for the popularity of this fiction, and that is that it serves the American perception of itself in the world as intrinsically benign. It also serves the American tendency to see any form of popular yearning for freedom and democracy as inherently American in character. Thus Hillary Clinton’s rhetoric switched in a second from ‘Mubarak’s a great guy and he should stay’ to ‘Isn’t it great what the Egyptian people have done, and isn’t it great how the United States did it for them?’ I will never know how she managed to keep a straight face when she proclaimed, on 15 February 2011, that Internet freedom was to be at the heart of American foreign policy on the very same day her government went to court to force Twitter to give up the account information of three members of WikiLeaks staff.

The fight against oppressive regimes begins, and will end, always, with the fight for information and communication. Egypt was not the Twitter Revolution, any more than the French Revolution was the revolution of the printing press and the political pamphlet; but what they both represent are revolutions of the people sharing ideas and information using the technology available to them, and expressing themselves in the public space. My friend John Pilger got it right when he said that it is not WikiLeaks the United States government is afraid of, and it is not Julian Assange that they are afraid of. What does it matter what I know? What does it matter what WikiLeaks knows? It matters not at all. What matters is what you know. This is all about you.

Back in Melbourne, in 2006, I’m glad to say some of the old hacking spirit remained. A bunch of us were living on a house at 177 Grattan Street, right next to a busy road, and the general chaos in the house was only made worse, I’m sure, by our mathematical adventures and nocturnal habits. In the flurry of working things out, I had scrawled algebra and diagrams first on a number of light boards, then on the walls and on the windows, on the tables and over anything flat, and sometimes the noise of traffic outside would become too much for concentration. There were traffic lights outside. One day, in the old style, we hacked into the city traffic system and changed